

RANJAN RAHI

Mohd Ayub Ansari (far left), one of the many skilled migrant workers who returned home during Covid-19, has found Jeeshan Jeans Traders at Chanpatia, making annual sales worth Rs 20 lakh

CHANPATIA STARTUP CLUSTER

West Champaran, Bihar

trains transported jobless migrant workers to government-run quarantine camps in Bihar. During this period, Chief Minister Nitish Kumar engaged with them via visits and video conferences. During one such conference at a West Champaran facility, Nitish instructed Kundan Kumar, then district magistrate, to skill-map the migrants for potential employment. The results revealed diverse expertise in embroidery, leather goods making, jeans production, utensil making, woodcraft, marketing, technical and other skills among the workers.

The DM held a series of discussions with the workers and discovered their desire to set up their own businesses. However, the biggest challenge was finances. While the administration lacked the means to assist, banks were hesitant to extend loans without collateral. Undeterred, Kundan Kumar conducted multiple meetings with bank officials, ultimately securing loans totalling Rs 11 crore for 59 workers. The funds enabled them to acquire power looms, computer-enabled embroidery machines and other equipment. The State Food Corporation godowns were vacated, allowing for the establishment of a business cluster in Chanpatia, 17 km from the district headquarters. Today, these entrepreneurs produce high-quality jackets, saris, shirts, utensils and other goods, selling them both locally and as far as eastern Uttar Pradesh and Nepal. The Chanpatia cluster, spanning over 1 lakh sq. ft, maintains an affordable rent of Rs 1.25 per sq. ft.

Since April 2021, these entrepreneurs have recorded a total sales figure of Rs 22 crore and are employing over 1,000 workers. Archana and her husband started their sari-lehenga manufacturing venture with a Rs 25 lakh loan. They have nearly repaid it and are now seeking additional funding for expansion. Sudama Patal, a 39-year-old former supervisor at a Ludhiana jeans factory, reported a turnover of Rs 50 lakh for his own unit, DKD Champaran Creations, during March-December 2023. Anand Kumar, 45, who transitioned from a worker to an entrepreneur in the steel utensil industry, now clocks sales in the "seven digits".

These success stories define the Chanpatia model, inspiring the state government to replicate it across Bihar. The establishment of a bag manufacturing cluster in Muzaffarpur, with 40 units having a monthly capacity of over 600,000 school bags, exemplifies this expansion. Kundan Kumar is no longer serving as the district magistrate, but the success of Chanpatia continues to motivate others, with 141 proposals submitted for similar ventures in West Champaran district. Deputy development commissioner Anil Kumar expresses the administration's commitment to amplifying this success. ■

HAPPINESS QUOTIENT

- **The Bihar government facilitated Rs 11 crore bank loans to skilled migrant workers who returned home during the Covid-19 lockdown**
- **Fifty-nine migrant workers have become successful entrepreneurs, employing over 1,000 people. They have made cumulative sales worth Rs 22 crore since April 2021**